

Name: _____

Date: _____

The Snowy Mountains Scheme

Year 5 reading comprehension · Information text · 15 marks · About 25 minutes

A huge idea

In the 1940s, much of inland Australia was dry. On the other side of the Great Dividing Range, the Snowy River tumbled to the sea. It begins high on the slopes near Mount Kosciuszko, and most of its water was not being used for farming. Engineers had a big idea: what if they sent some of that water through the mountains?

Building the Scheme

Construction of the Snowy Mountains Scheme began in 1949 and took 25 years. When it was finished in 1974, it included 16 major dams, seven power stations and about 145 kilometres of tunnels drilled through the mountains. Workers blasted the tunnels out of hard rock, often deep underground, through bitter alpine winters of deep snow and freezing winds. The water now flows west into the Murray and Murrumbidgee rivers, helping farms far inland, and it also generates electricity on the way.

People from many lands

More than 100,000 people worked on the Scheme, and about two-thirds of them came from overseas. They came from more than 30 countries, including Italy, Germany and Norway. Many lived in remote camps and towns in the cold mountains, working side by side with people who spoke different languages. Two towns, Adaminaby and Jindabyne, were even moved to new sites so that their valleys could be flooded to make lakes. A lot of the workers stayed in Australia afterwards and made their homes here.

A mixed legacy

Today, the Scheme still makes electricity for homes and businesses. It has been called one of the engineering wonders of the modern world. However, diverting so much water changed the Snowy River itself, and in recent years more water has been released back into the river. People still discuss how to share water fairly between farms, electricity and nature.

1. In which year did construction of the Snowy Mountains Scheme begin? (1 mark)

2. Give two things that the Snowy Mountains Scheme included when it was finished. (2 marks)

3. The text says the Snowy River “tumbled to the sea.” What does the word “tumbled” suggest about the river? (1 mark)

4. Why was the Scheme built? Use evidence from the text. (2 marks)

5. The text says people worked “side by side with people who spoke different languages.” What does this suggest about the people who worked there? (2 marks)

6. Quote the sentence from the last section that shows the Scheme had a downside. Use quotation marks. (2 marks)

7. The last section is called “A mixed legacy.” What do you think “mixed” means here? Use the text to explain. (2 marks)

8. Summarise the text in three sentences. Include why the Scheme was built, who built it, and what it changed. (3 marks)

Writing task: Imagine you are a young worker who has just arrived at a Snowy Mountains camp from another country. Write a letter home.
